Shorts scripts

Built 2026-10-30 · 18 scripts

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P06: The hot hand was "debunked" for 30 years. Then someone checked the math.

- **Category:** NBA
- **Concepts:** hot hand fallacy, how people misjudge randomness, the "law of small numbers," science correcting itself
- **Target length:** ~4:00 (~600 words) · post as a regular video (over the 3-minute Shorts limit)
- **Title:** Is the "hot hand" real? Psychology got it wrong for 30 years
- **Thumbnail text:** "37 POINTS. 1 QUARTER."

COLD OPEN

January 23rd, 2015. Klay Thompson walks out for the third quarter against the Sacramento Kings and does something nobody in NBA history had ever done. He scores 37 points. In one quarter. Thirteen shots, thirteen makes, nine of them threes. By the end, his teammates were basically handing him the ball and getting out of the way. Everyone in that building believed the same thing: Klay was hot. And for thirty years, psychologists said that belief was an illusion. Then two economists found a mistake in the math.

1. THE STUDY THAT "KILLED" THE HOT HAND

In 1985, three psychologists, Thomas Gilovich, Robert Vallone and Amos Tversky, tested it. Tversky is half of the duo that basically invented behavioral economics, so this was a big deal. They looked at shooting records from the Philadelphia 76ers, free throws from the Boston Celtics, and a controlled shooting experiment with Cornell's basketball teams. The question was simple: after a player hits a few in a row, is he more likely to hit the next one? Their answer was no. The streaks were just what randomness looks like.

2. WHY YOUR BRAIN SEES STREAKS

Here's the thing about randomness: it's streakier than you think. Flip a coin twenty times, and the odds are about three in four that you'll get at least four of the same side in a row. But ask people to write down a "random" sequence and they flip back and forth way too often. We expect random to look balanced, so when we see a streak, we assume something is causing it. That became the "hot hand fallacy." It went into textbooks and economics classes. Coaches who believed in the hot hand got treated like people who believe in horoscopes.

3. THE PLOT TWIST

In 2015, economists Joshua Miller and Adam Sanjurjo found a problem. Not with the basketball. With the counting. Try this: flip a coin four times. Look at every flip that comes right after a heads, and

check what percent of those were heads too. Do that for thousands of four-flip sequences and average it. It's a fair coin, so you'd expect fifty percent. You get about forty. The coin has no memory. The way you're counting short streaks just quietly tilts the result. And the 1985 study counted exactly that way. So a purely random shooter should have looked a little *cold* in their data. The real players looked about even. Correct for the bias, and they were shooting *better* after makes. Miller and Sanjurjo reran the original data and found a real hot hand. Their paper came out in 2018 in one of the top economics journals.

4. SO WHO'S RIGHT?
Gilovich pushed back. He told the New York Times their samples were big enough that the conclusion holds. Other researchers using modern tracking data found something in between: players who feel hot really do shoot a little better, but they also start taking harder shots, which hides the effect. Where things roughly stand now: the hot hand is probably real, just smaller than it feels. Klay's night was real. Your friend hitting two in a row at the rec center? Probably still mostly luck.

OUTRO

The lesson isn't "trust your gut" or "your gut is wrong." It's that one of the most famous findings in psychology was knocked over by a counting error, and it took thirty years for anyone to notice. Science corrects itself. Just slower than a Klay Thompson third quarter. So next time your teammate hits three in a row, give him the ball. Just not every time. Subscribe if you want more sports stories where the psychology is weirder than the highlight.

Visuals: no NBA footage or photos (the NBA enforces its copyright hard). Use a text card with "13/13 FG · 9/9 3PT · 37 PTS", and do the coin-flip demo live on camera with a real coin. The "50% → 40%" reveal works as a big on-screen number.

Sources:
- Klay Thompson's 37-point quarter: Jan 23, 2015 vs. Sacramento (NBA record for points in a quarter).
- Gilovich, T., Vallone, R., & Tversky, A. (1985). The hot hand in basketball. *Cognitive Psychology*, 17, 295–314.
- Miller, J. B., & Sanjurjo, A. (2018). Surprised by the hot hand fallacy? A truth in the law of small numbers. *Econometrica*, 86(6), 2019–2047. (4-flip example: expected share ≈ 40.5%.)
- Bocskocsky, A., Ezekowitz, J., & Stein, C. (2014). The hot hand: A new approach to an old "fallacy." MIT Sloan Sports Analytics Conference. (Hot players take harder shots.)
- Streak odds: P(4+ of the same side in a row in 20 fair flips) ≈ 77%, computed.

P07: Why NBA players refuse the free throw that works

- **Category:** NBA
- **Concepts:** social image vs. performance, threshold models of conformity, "precarious manhood," choking under pressure
- **Target length:** ~3:45 (~560 words) · regular video
- **Title:** Wilt Chamberlain found the perfect free throw. Then he quit using it.
- **Thumbnail text:** "TOO EMBARRASSING TO WORK"

COLD OPEN

March 2nd, 1962. Wilt Chamberlain scores 100 points in one NBA game, a record that still stands. Here's the part nobody talks about: 28 of those points were free throws. He went 28 for 32 that night, and Wilt was usually a terrible free throw shooter. His secret? He shot them underhanded. Granny style. The next season, he stopped. He went back to the normal way, and he went back to missing. This video is about why someone would knowingly choose to be worse at their job.

1. THE SHOT THAT WORKS

Wilt didn't invent it. He got it from Rick Barry, a Hall of Famer who shot underhanded his entire career and made almost 90 percent of his free throws. That's elite, in any era. Barry's argument is simple: your arms hang straight down naturally, you use both hands so the ball doesn't drift sideways, and the ball drops in softer with more arc. And if you're a seven-footer with big hands and stiff shoulders, the normal free throw is genuinely awkward for your body. The underhand shot fixes that.

2. WHY PLAYERS WON'T DO IT

Wilt explained why he quit in his own book. He said shooting that way made him feel silly. Like a "sissy." Decades later, Barry reportedly offered to teach Shaquille O'Neal, one of the worst free throw shooters ever. Shaq's answer, as the story goes: he'd rather shoot zero percent. Teams literally built a strategy around his misses. They called it "Hack-a-Shaq." And still, almost nobody switched.

3. THE PSYCHOLOGY: NOBODY WANTS TO GO FIRST

Sociologist Mark Granovetter has a model for this. Everyone has a threshold: how many other people have to do something before you'll do it too. A few people have a threshold of zero; they'll do anything first. Most people need to see lots of others do it. Malcolm Gladwell used this exact model to explain the granny shot. For the underhand free throw, almost every player's threshold is sky-high, so nobody goes first, so nobody's threshold ever gets met. Add what psychologists call "precarious manhood": research finds manhood is seen as something you can lose, so men will pay real costs to

avoid looking unmanly. For an NBA player, looking goofy in front of 20,000 people and millions on TV is one of those costs.

4. THE IRONY: PRESSURE MAKES IT WORSE

Free throws are the one moment in basketball where the game stops and everyone stares at you. Research on choking, by psychologists like Sian Beilock, finds that skilled athletes under pressure start consciously monitoring movements that are usually automatic, and that's exactly when they break down. So a player afraid of looking weird is already thinking too much about how he looks while he shoots. The fear of embarrassment adds to the very pressure that makes him miss.

OUTRO

We all have a granny free throw. The study method that looks nerdy. The question you won't ask in lecture. Going to the gym when you don't know what you're doing. The real question isn't "what works?" It's "what am I willing to look stupid doing?" Wilt Chamberlain picked looking cool over 100-point nights. Most of us make the same trade, just smaller, every day. Comment your granny free throw. Mine's [Ark: fill in yours].

Visuals: demo both shooting motions with a ball (no hoop needed). Text card: "Wilt 1962: 28/32 underhand." No NBA footage.

Sources:

- Wilt Chamberlain's 100-point game, Mar 2, 1962: 28/32 FT, shot underhanded (History.com; Gladwell, *Revisionist History* S1E3 "The Big Man Can't Shoot," 2016).
- Rick Barry career NBA FT% ≈ 89–90% (Basketball-Reference).
- Shaq quote: as told by Rick Barry and Gladwell; keep "reportedly."
- Granovetter, M. (1978). Threshold models of collective behavior. *American Journal of Sociology*, 83(6).
- Vandello, J. A., Bosson, J. K., Cohen, D., Burnaford, R. M., & Weaver, J. R. (2008). Precarious manhood. *JPSP*, 95(6), 1325–1339.
- Beilock, S. L., & Carr, T. H. (2001). On the fragility of skilled performance: What governs choking under pressure? *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 130(4).

P08: How do you blow a 29-point lead? (Cavs vs. Sixers, opening night)

- **Category:** NBA, current season
- **Concepts:** loss aversion, "playing not to lose," ironic process theory, the momentum myth
- **Target length:** ~3:30 (~540 words) · regular video · **film soon**: this is timely
- **Title:** The psychology of blowing a 29-point lead
- **Thumbnail text:** "UP 29. LOST."

COLD OPEN

October 22nd, 2026. Opening night in Philadelphia. LeBron James's first home game as a Sixer. The Cleveland Cavaliers go up by 29 points. Twenty-nine. Then they lose, 114 to 106. Philly closes on a 15–0 run in the fourth quarter. It was the biggest comeback of LeBron's entire career, and he's been in the league since 2003. The Cavs had never lost a game after leading by that much. So what actually happens inside a team's head when a lead like that melts?

1. FROM "WIN" TO "DON'T LOSE"

Psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky showed that losses hurt more than equal gains feel good. Losing $100 stings about twice as much as finding $100 feels nice. Now think about a team up 29. They're not chasing anything anymore. They're protecting something. The goal quietly flips from "go win this" to "don't be the team that blows this." And people in "don't lose" mode tend to play safer and slower, and get more anxious about every mistake. That's not a strategy, it's a mood.

2. TRYING NOT TO MESS UP CAN MAKE YOU MESS UP

Psychologist Daniel Wegner studied "ironic processes": trying hard *not* to think of something makes you think of it more. In one study, golfers told to putt and specifically *not* overshoot the hole, while distracted, overshot it more often. So imagine a coach in a timeout yelling "Stop turning it over!" Cleveland finished with 21 turnovers and shot 7 for 29 from three. I can't read their minds, and some of it was just Tyrese Maxey and the Sixers' defense being great. But it's exactly what this research would predict.

3. WAIT, ISN'T IT JUST MOMENTUM?

Everybody on TV says "momentum." Here's what the data says. Researchers at Ben-Gurion University looked at almost 900 NBA games where a team came back from behind to force overtime. If momentum is a real force, the comeback team should win overtime more often. They didn't. Home court and team quality mattered. "Momentum" didn't. A follow-up study found sports fans believe in

momentum even more strongly than non-fans do. So momentum might be less of a physical force and more of a story we tell after the fact.

4. THEN WHY DO COLLAPSES FEEL REAL?
Because the story inside the players' heads is real, even if "momentum" isn't. A lead going from 29 to 15 to 6 feels like falling, and that feeling changes decisions: rushed possessions, hero-ball, passes thrown out of fear. The scoreboard didn't cause the collapse. What the players believed the scoreboard *meant* did.

OUTRO

You don't need to be an NBA player for this. Ever been up big in a game, a class, a relationship, and started playing scared? The fix the research points to is boring but real: keep focusing on the next play, not the lead. Play like you're tied. The Cavs will be fine; it's game one of 82. But if you want to know how good teams lose, it usually starts the moment they stop trying to win. Comment the worst collapse you've ever watched.

Visuals: no NBA footage. Animated scoreboard text cards: "CLE +29 → PHI 114–106", "15–0 run", "21 turnovers · 7/29 from three." Check the box score once more before filming.

Sources:
- Game: Oct 22, 2026, 76ers 114, Cavaliers 106 (AP/Yahoo Sports; CBS Sports box score). Maxey 32, Embiid 24, Brown 21, LeBron 17/10; Mitchell 32/10; CLE 21 TOV, 7/29 3PT. Biggest comeback win of LeBron's career; Cavs' first loss after leading by that much.
- Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect theory. *Econometrica*, 47(2).
- Wegner, D. M., Ansfield, M., & Pilloff, D. (1998). The putt and the pendulum: Ironic effects of the mental control of action. *Psychological Science*, 9(3).
- Morgulev, E., Azar, O. H., & Bar-Eli, M. (2019). Does a "comeback" create momentum in overtime? Analysis of NBA tied games. *Journal of Economic Psychology*, 75. Plus the 2020 *Judgment and Decision Making* follow-up on fans' momentum beliefs.

P09: Walter White didn't break bad. He justified his way there.

- **Category:** TV
- **Concepts:** cognitive dissonance (Festinger), the $1/$20 study, the "pyramid of choice," self-justification
- **Target length:** ~4:00 (~590 words) · regular video · spoilers for all of *Breaking Bad*
- **Title:** The psychology that turned Walter White into Heisenberg
- **Thumbnail text:** "HE DID IT FOR HIS FAMILY?"

COLD OPEN

Vince Gilligan pitched *Breaking Bad* in one line: turning Mr. Chips into Scarface. A mild chemistry teacher becomes a drug lord. But watch it again and you'll notice Walter White never actually *decides* to become evil. Not once. Every step makes perfect sense to him. And that's what makes the show terrifying, because there's a psychology concept that explains every single step, and it works on you too. Spoilers ahead, obviously.

1. THE DISCOMFORT THAT RUNS YOUR BRAIN

In 1957, psychologist Leon Festinger described cognitive dissonance: the uncomfortable tension you feel when your actions don't match your beliefs. And here's the key part: when that happens, you usually don't change the action. You change the belief. Because the action already happened, and the belief is easier to edit.

2. THE $1 EXPERIMENT

Two years later, Festinger and James Carlsmith ran one of the most famous studies in psychology. Students spent an hour on a mind-numbingly boring task, turning pegs on a board. Then they were paid to tell the next student it was fun. Some got $20. Some got one dollar. Later, who said the task was actually more enjoyable? The one-dollar group. The $20 people had an excuse: "I lied for the money." The $1 people didn't. So their brains quietly solved the problem: "Maybe it wasn't that boring."

3. WALT'S PYRAMID

Psychologists Carol Tavris and Elliot Aronson describe a "pyramid of choice." Two people start at the top, nearly identical. They face a small choice, like whether to cheat on one exam. One cheats, one doesn't. Each then justifies their choice, and the justifying pushes them further apart until they end up at opposite corners of the pyramid, convinced they were always different people. Now watch Walt. Cook once: "it's for my family." Let someone die: "I had no choice." Poison a child to manipulate

Jesse: "It was necessary." Every justification makes the next step smaller. He never jumps off a cliff. He walks down a staircase.

4. JESSE: THE GUY WHO COULDN'T JUSTIFY

Here's the part people miss. Jesse Pinkman does a lot of the same things. But Jesse never fully justifies them. He keeps feeling the guilt. So the dissonance doesn't go away. It eats him alive: the drugs, the breakdowns, the self-hatred. Walt resolves the tension by rewriting his beliefs. Jesse resolves nothing. That's the dark truth of dissonance. Self-justification protects you from feeling bad, and it also blocks you from getting better.

5. THE CONFESSION

That's why the finale lands. Walt finally tells Skyler, "I did it for me. I liked it. I was good at it." After five seasons of "for my family," the justification finally drops. It's the first fully honest thing he's said in the whole show.

OUTRO

None of us are cooking meth. But we all have a little Walt in us: the friend we ghosted and decided was annoying anyway, the shortcut at work that became "everybody does it." The defense isn't to never make mistakes. It's to notice the moment you start explaining why it was fine. That little voice saying "but it was for a good reason"? That's where Heisenberg starts. Which character do you think was actually the most self-aware? Tell me in the comments.

Visuals: stills OK under the 2026-10-25 rule: 1–3 s studio publicity stills (TMDB) for Walt / Jesse, approved by Ark first. No clips, no show audio. Draw the pyramid on paper or as a simple graphic.

Sources:

- Gilligan's "Mr. Chips into Scarface" pitch: widely quoted (e.g., *The New York Times*, 2011 interviews).
- Festinger, L. (1957). *A Theory of Cognitive Dissonance*.
- Festinger, L., & Carlsmith, J. M. (1959). Cognitive consequences of forced compliance. *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology*, 58(2), 203–210.
- Tavris, C., & Aronson, E. (2007). *Mistakes Were Made (But Not by Me)*. (Pyramid of choice.)
- Finale quote: *Breaking Bad* S5E16 "Felina" (2013). Short quote used for commentary.

P10: Why The Office physically hurts to watch

- **Category:** TV
- **Concepts:** vicarious embarrassment (brain imaging), empathy, the spotlight effect, benign masochism
- **Target length:** ~3:45 (~560 words) · regular video
- **Title:** Why Michael Scott makes you physically cringe (it's science)
- **Thumbnail text:** "YOUR BRAIN ON 'DINNER PARTY'"

COLD OPEN

Some people can't watch *The Office*. Not because it's bad. Because it hurts. Michael Scott does something unbearable, and they have to pause it, leave the room, cover their face with a pillow. If that's you, you're not being dramatic. Your brain is reacting to Michael's embarrassment almost the way it reacts to someone getting physically hurt.

1. YOUR FLAWS ARE MY PAIN

In 2011, a team of German researchers published a study with the best title in psychology: "Your Flaws Are My Pain." They put people in a brain scanner and showed them scenes of other people embarrassing themselves. Two brain areas lit up: the anterior cingulate cortex and the anterior insula. Those are the same areas that respond when you watch someone get *physically* hurt. And here's the wild part: it happened even when the person on screen had no idea they were being embarrassing. Which is basically Michael Scott's whole personality.

2. WHY SOME PEOPLE CRINGE HARDER

The same study found the people who cringed hardest scored higher in empathy. So if you can't make it through "Scott's Tots," it doesn't mean you're soft. It means your brain is really good at putting you in someone else's shoes, even when those shoes belong to a man who promised a classroom of kids he'd pay for their college.

3. THE OPPOSITE PROBLEM: THE SPOTLIGHT EFFECT

Here's the twist. We feel other people's embarrassment intensely. But we massively overestimate how much other people notice *ours*. In a classic study, Cornell psychologist Thomas Gilovich had students put on an embarrassing Barry Manilow T-shirt and walk into a room full of people. They guessed about half the room would notice. The real number was about a quarter. It's called the spotlight effect. You're the main character in your own head, but everyone else is busy being the main character in theirs. Michael Scott is the extreme version: he thinks everyone is watching him, and he's literally right, because there's a documentary crew.

4. THEN WHY DO WE KEEP WATCHING?

If it hurts, why is *The Office* one of the most rewatched shows ever? Psychologist Paul Rozin calls it

"benign masochism": enjoying a negative feeling when you know you're actually safe. It's the same reason people love hot sauce, horror movies and sad songs. Your body says "danger," your brain knows it's fine, and the gap between those two feels weirdly good. Cringe comedy is a roller coaster for your social brain.

OUTRO

So next time you cringe at Michael, remember two things. One: that's empathy, it's a good sign. Two: the next time *you* do something embarrassing, about half as many people noticed as you think, and most of them forgot by lunch. Michael Scott had a camera crew. You don't. Which episode is the hardest one for you to watch? I'm guessing "Dinner Party."

Visuals: 1–3 s publicity stills (TMDB, Ark approves each), no clips or show audio. A cheap "embarrassing T-shirt" prop for beat 3 would be great.

Sources:

- Krach, S., Cohrs, J. C., et al. (2011). Your flaws are my pain: Linking empathy to vicarious embarrassment. *PLoS ONE*, 6(4), e18675.
- Gilovich, T., Medvec, V. H., & Savitsky, K. (2000). The spotlight effect in social judgment. *JPSP*, 78(2), 211–222. (Predicted ≈ 50% noticed; actual ≈ 25%.)
- Rozin, P., Guillot, L., Fincher, K., Rozin, A., & Tsukayama, E. (2013). Glad to be sad, and other examples of benign masochism. *Judgment and Decision Making*, 8(4).

P11: Why the Roy kids can never walk away from Logan

- **Category:** TV
- **Concepts:** intermittent reinforcement (Skinner), traumatic bonding, conditional regard from parents
- **Target length:** ~3:45 (~560 words) · regular video · spoilers for *Succession*
- **Title:** Succession is a psychology experiment, and the kids are the rats
- **Thumbnail text:** "THE SLOT MACHINE DAD"

COLD OPEN

Logan Roy insults his kids, betrays them, humiliates them in front of the whole company. And every season, they come crawling back. Kendall, Shiv, Roman: smart, rich, adult people who could walk away any day. They don't. Viewers yell "just leave!" at the screen. But psychology has a pretty precise explanation for why they can't, and it's the same thing that makes slot machines work.

1. THE PIGEON EXPERIMENT

In the 1950s, B.F. Skinner trained animals by rewarding them for pressing a lever. He found something strange. If you reward them *every* time, they learn fast but quit fast once the reward stops. If you reward them *unpredictably*, sometimes after 3 presses, sometimes after 30, they press like crazy and keep pressing long after the rewards stop. That's called a variable-ratio schedule, or intermittent reinforcement. It's the most addictive reward pattern there is. Casinos built an industry on it.

2. LOGAN IS A SLOT MACHINE

Now look at Logan. He doesn't give his kids love. He gives them *maybe*. Maybe you're the successor. Maybe you're "number one boy." Then it's gone. Then, just when they're about to give up, a crumb: a hand on the shoulder, a "you did good." Every one of the Roy kids is pulling the lever, waiting for the jackpot of being chosen. And because the payout is random, they can never stop pulling.

3. WHY IT BONDS YOU HARDER

Psychologists Donald Dutton and Susan Painter studied what they called "traumatic bonding." People in relationships that swing between mistreatment and affection often form *stronger* attachments, not weaker ones. The relief after cruelty feels like love. It's not the kids being stupid. It's their nervous systems being trained.

4. LOVE WITH CONDITIONS

There's one more layer. Researchers Avi Assor, Guy Roth and Edward Deci studied "conditional regard," parents who give love only when kids perform. Their kids did push themselves hard, but they also felt more resentment toward their parents, and their self-worth swung up and down with every

success and failure. That's the Roy kids in one sentence. Kendall's whole identity rises and falls on whether Dad approves today.

5. THE LINE THAT EXPLAINS IT
Near the end, Logan tells his kids, "I love you, but you are not serious people." Even his "I love you" comes with a "but." That's conditional regard in nine words.

OUTRO

The reason *Succession* hits so hard is that a lot of people recognize it. A parent, a boss, an ex who was amazing just often enough. If you've ever stayed somewhere because of the good days you were waiting for, that's intermittent reinforcement, and knowing the name for it is the first step to noticing it. Who do you think came closest to actually breaking free? I'll say it: none of them.

Visuals: 1–3 s publicity stills of Logan and the kids (TMDB, Ark approves each); no clips or show audio. A cheap slot-machine graphic or a phone slot-machine app for the cold open.

Sources:
- Ferster, C. B., & Skinner, B. F. (1957). *Schedules of Reinforcement*. (Variable-ratio schedules: high, persistent response rates.)
- Dutton, D. G., & Painter, S. L. (1981). Traumatic bonding. *Victimology*, 6; (1993) *Violence and Victims*, 8(2).
- Assor, A., Roth, G., & Deci, E. L. (2004). The emotional costs of parents' conditional regard. *Journal of Personality*, 72(1), 47–88.
- Quote: *Succession* S4E2 "Rehearsal" (2023). Short quote used for commentary.

P12: The Joker's ferry experiment was wrong (and the movie knew it)

- **Category:** Film
- **Concepts:** the "panic myth" in disasters, emergent shared identity, attitudes vs. behavior (LaPiere)
- **Target length:** ~4:00 (~590 words) · regular video
- **Title:** The Joker's social experiment, tested against real disasters
- **Thumbnail text:** "WOULD YOU PRESS IT?"

COLD OPEN

In *The Dark Knight*, the Joker runs a social experiment. Two ferries, both rigged with bombs. One full of regular citizens, one full of prisoners. Each boat holds the detonator for the *other* boat. If nobody presses it by midnight, he blows up both. The Joker's whole philosophy is that when things get bad, people turn on each other. Civilization is a thin coat of paint. So, was he right? We actually have decades of real data on how people behave in disasters, and the answer surprised a lot of researchers.

1. THE PANIC MYTH

Sociologist Enrico Quarantelli spent about fifty years studying real disasters: floods, fires, explosions, hundreds of field studies. Over and over, he found almost no real panic. No stampedes of people trampling each other to survive. What he found instead was people helping. The idea that crowds go feral in a crisis is so common, and so wrong, that researchers call it the panic myth.

2. WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY DID

On September 11th, survivors of the World Trade Center described a mostly calm, orderly evacuation, with strangers helping each other down the stairs. After the 2005 London bombings, psychologist John Drury and colleagues interviewed survivors from the attacked trains and found the same thing: people comforted strangers, shared water, helped the injured. Drury's explanation is that disasters create a sudden shared identity. A train car full of strangers becomes "us." The danger doesn't dissolve the group. It creates one.

3. BUT THE CIVILIANS VOTED TO DO IT

Here's where the movie gets really smart. On the civilian ferry, they hold a vote, and the majority votes to blow up the prisoners. On paper, the Joker wins. But when it's time to actually press the button, nobody can do it. And on the prisoner boat, a huge inmate takes the detonator and throws it out the window.

4. WHAT WE SAY VS. WHAT WE DO

That gap has a name in psychology, and the classic study on it is personal to me. In the early 1930s, sociologist Richard LaPiere traveled the US with a young Chinese couple, at a time when anti-Asian prejudice was open and normal. They visited more than 250 hotels and restaurants. They were refused service once. Then LaPiere mailed those same businesses a letter asking, "Will you accept members of the Chinese race as guests?" About nine out of ten who answered said no. What people say in the abstract and what they do face to face with a real human can be completely different. The civilians voted against an idea: "prisoners." They couldn't press the button on actual people.

5. THE REAL MONSTER IN DISASTERS

Disaster researchers have one more term worth knowing: "elite panic." Often the people who panic in a crisis are the ones in charge, because they *assume* the public will panic, then make decisions like withholding information. The Joker is the ultimate elite panicker. He's so sure people are monsters that he can't see the evidence in front of him.

OUTRO

The Joker said people are only as good as the world allows them to be. The research says the opposite: when the world falls apart, people usually get better. That's not naive. It's data. Would you have pressed the button? Be honest in the comments.

Visuals: 1–3 s publicity stills (TMDB, Ark approves each), no clips or movie audio. A cheap "detonator" prop (a remote or a box) for the cold open. Text card for LaPiere: "~250 visits → refused 1 time / letters → ~90% said NO."

Sources:

- Quarantelli, E. L. (2001). The sociology of panic; (2008) Conventional beliefs and counterintuitive realities. *Social Research*, 75(3). (University of Delaware Disaster Research Center.)
- WTC evacuation: NIST and Columbia/CDC World Trade Center evacuation studies; Clarke, L. (2002). Panic: Myth or reality? *Contexts*, 1(3).
- Drury, J., Cocking, C., & Reicher, S. (2009). Everyone for themselves? A comparative study of crowd solidarity among emergency survivors. *British Journal of Social Psychology*, 48(3). (Includes the 2005 London bombings.)
- LaPiere, R. T. (1934). Attitudes vs. actions. *Social Forces*, 13(2), 230–237. (251 establishments, refused once; ~92% of replies said no.)
- Clarke, L., & Chess, C. (2008). Elites and panic: More to fear than fear itself. *Social Forces*, 87(2).

P13: Does Whiplash-style abuse actually make people great?

- **Category:** Film (with an NBA tie-in)
- **Concepts:** controlling vs. autonomy-supportive coaching (self-determination theory), arousal and performance, survivorship bias
- **Target length:** ~4:00 (~600 words) · regular video
- **Title:** Fletcher was wrong: what research says about abusive coaches
- **Thumbnail text:** "NOT MY TEMPO"

COLD OPEN

In *Whiplash*, the music teacher Terence Fletcher throws chairs, slaps students and screams until a 19-year-old drummer's hands bleed. His defense is a story: a young Charlie Parker got a cymbal thrown at his head for playing badly, went home, practiced like crazy, and came back as a legend. Fletcher says the two most harmful words in the English language are "good job." A lot of people watched that movie and thought: he's a monster, but he's kind of right. So is he? Does pushing people through fear actually create greatness?

1. THE CYMBAL NEVER HIT HIS HEAD

Start with the story itself. Charlie Parker was a teenager at a jam session in Kansas City in the 1930s. He lost his place, and the drummer, Jo Jones, took a cymbal off his kit and threw it on the floor at Parker's feet. It was a "get off the stage" signal, like the vaudeville gong. Humiliating? Absolutely. Attempted decapitation? No. Parker did go away and practice obsessively. But that's the point: the drive came from Parker, not from the cymbal. The movie made the story more violent, and Fletcher's whole philosophy is built on that exaggerated version.

2. WHAT THE RESEARCH ACTUALLY SAYS

Psychologists have studied coaching styles for decades through what's called self-determination theory. The big split is "controlling" versus "autonomy-supportive." Controlling coaches use fear, guilt, humiliation and "do it because I said so." Autonomy-supportive coaches give reasons, choices and real feedback, and they still push hard. Study after study links controlling coaching to athletes who feel more anxious, burn out more, and are more likely to quit. Autonomy-supportive coaching goes with better motivation and longer careers. High standards aren't the problem. Fear is.

3. FEAR HELPS SIMPLE TASKS, HURTS HARD ONES

There's a classic idea called the Yerkes–Dodson law. Some stress makes you perform better, but past a certain point it makes you worse, and that tipping point comes sooner on complex tasks. Lifting a

heavy box while scared? Fine. Improvising jazz at 400 beats per minute? Fear is a terrible fuel for that. Creativity needs a brain that isn't busy surviving.

4. THE NBA CHECKED THIS
Look at basketball. Phil Jackson won 11 championships as a coach, more than anyone in NBA history. He was famous for meditation sessions, giving players books to read, and treating stars like adults. He still demanded a lot. He just didn't rule by terror. The most decorated coach in the sport is basically the anti-Fletcher.

5. THE FLETCHER ILLUSION
So why does the Fletcher myth survive? Survivorship bias. We hear about the one student who got screamed at and became great. We never hear about the hundred who got screamed at and quit music forever. Even in the movie, one of Fletcher's former students dies by suicide, and Fletcher tells the class it was a car accident. The successes are loud. The casualties are quiet.

OUTRO

High standards and abuse are not the same thing. The best coaches, teachers and bosses push you hard *and* make you feel like you can do it. If someone is only ever making you feel small, that isn't the secret to greatness. That's just someone being cruel and calling it a method. Have you ever had a "Fletcher"? Did it make you better, or just make you quit?

Visuals: 1–3 s publicity stills (TMDB, Ark approves each), no clips or movie audio. A cymbal sound effect from a royalty-free library is fine; the movie's audio is not.

Sources:
- Jo Jones / Charlie Parker cymbal incident (Reno Club, Kansas City, ~1936–37); thrown at his feet, not his head (Wikipedia: Jo Jones; National Jazz Archive, "Charlie Parker: myth and mayhem," 2020).
- Mageau, G. A., & Vallerand, R. J. (2003). The coach–athlete relationship: A motivational model. *Journal of Sports Sciences*, 21(11).
- Bartholomew, K. J., Ntoumanis, N., Ryan, R. M., & Thøgersen-Ntoumani, C. (2011). Psychological need thwarting in the sport context. *Journal of Sport & Exercise Psychology*, 33(1).
- Yerkes, R. M., & Dodson, J. D. (1908). The relation of strength of stimulus to rapidity of habit-formation. *Journal of Comparative Neurology and Psychology*, 18.
- Phil Jackson: 11 NBA titles as head coach (NBA record).
- Beat 5 mentions suicide briefly. YouTube allows it, but keep it non-graphic as written.

P14: "The Truman Show Delusion" is a real thing psychiatrists see

- **Category:** Film
- **Concepts:** how culture shapes the content of delusions, the Gold brothers' research, surveillance in the age of reality TV
- **Target length:** ~3:30 (~520 words) · regular video
- **Title:** A movie gave its name to a real psychiatric delusion
- **Thumbnail text:** "THEY THOUGHT THEY WERE TRUMAN"

COLD OPEN

In 1998, Jim Carrey played Truman Burbank, a man who slowly realizes his entire life is a TV show. His wife is an actor. His best friend is an actor. The sky is a dome. It's a great movie. A few years later, a patient walked into Bellevue Hospital in New York and told a psychiatrist that *he* was living in a reality show. He wasn't joking. And he wasn't the only one.

1. THE PATIENTS

The psychiatrist was Joel Gold. Over the next few years, he saw several patients at Bellevue with the same belief: that they were being secretly filmed, that the people around them were actors, that their lives were being broadcast for other people's entertainment. Some of them mentioned *The Truman Show* by name. Joel and his brother Ian Gold, a philosopher and psychiatry researcher at McGill University, wrote about it, and in 2008 they gave it a name: the Truman Show delusion.

2. IT'S NOT AN OFFICIAL DIAGNOSIS, BUT IT'S REAL

To be clear, it's not in the diagnostic manual. It's a *theme*, a specific flavor of a well-known type of delusion, mostly a mix of paranoia ("I'm being watched") and grandiosity ("my life is important enough to be a TV show"). It usually shows up as part of a serious condition like psychosis, which is treatable. This isn't a funny quirk. For the people who have it, it's frightening.

3. DELUSIONS FOLLOW THE NEWS

Here's why the Golds found it so interesting. The *categories* of delusions have barely changed across history: being persecuted, being watched, being controlled. But the *content* changes with the culture. Centuries ago, people believed they were being tormented by demons or witches. In the radio era, it was radio waves in their heads. During the Cold War, it was government implants and KGB spies. And once reality TV took over the world, it became hidden cameras. The brain's fears stay the same. It just borrows the scariest technology of the moment to explain them.

4. AND THEN THE WORLD CAUGHT UP

The wildest part: *Big Brother* premiered in the Netherlands in 1999, one year after *The Truman Show*.

Within a decade, reality TV was everywhere. Now we have doorbell cameras, location sharing, and social media, where we basically broadcast our own lives on purpose. Ian Gold has argued that a culture this saturated with surveillance gives an anxious mind plenty of material. The Truman Show delusion may just be the first delusion of the reality-TV age.

OUTRO

So a movie about a fake life ended up describing a very real experience for real people. That's the strange loop of pop culture: it doesn't just reflect our minds, it gives our minds new stories to tell. If you or someone you know ever feels like the world is staged around you, that's worth talking to a professional about, not just a funny coincidence. Let me know in the comments what movie you'd want me to break down next.

Visuals: 1–3 s publicity still of Truman (TMDB, Ark approves), no clips or movie audio. A timeline graphic: demons → radio waves → implants → cameras.

Sources:

- Gold, J., & Gold, I. (2012). The "Truman Show" delusion: Psychosis in the global village. *Cognitive Neuropsychiatry*, 17(6), 455–472.
- Gold, J., & Gold, I. (2014). *Suspicious Minds: How Culture Shapes Madness*. Free Press.
- McGill University newsroom coverage of Ian Gold's research.
- *Big Brother* premiered in the Netherlands in September 1999.
- Mentions psychosis: kept non-stigmatizing, with a nudge toward professional help.

P15: Why politicians talk like 6th graders (and why it works on you)

- **Category:** Politics (**strictly nonpartisan**: examples from both parties, no policy opinions)
- **Concepts:** processing fluency, the illusory truth effect, rhyme-as-reason, readability
- **Target length:** ~3:45 (~560 words) · regular video · **timely: US midterms are Tuesday, Nov 3**
- **Title:** The psychology of political slogans: why simple wins
- **Thumbnail text:** "5TH GRADE LEVEL"

COLD OPEN

November 19th, 1863. Edward Everett, the most famous speaker in America, gives a speech at Gettysburg. It runs about two hours. Then Abraham Lincoln stands up and talks for about two minutes, and *that's* the one carved in stone. With elections on Tuesday, you're about to hear a lot of politicians talk. Here's the psychology of why the simplest lines win, and why your brain falls for them no matter which side you're on.

1. THE GRADE-LEVEL STUDY

In 2016, researchers at Carnegie Mellon ran presidential candidates' speeches through readability tests, the same tools used to grade school textbooks. Most candidates, from both parties, spoke at about a 6th to 8th grade level. Donald Trump's grammar came in just under 6th grade. Lincoln's Gettysburg Address? Around 11th grade. The study was small and not peer-reviewed, so don't overread it. But the pattern is real: modern campaign speech is simple, on purpose.

2. EASY FEELS TRUE

Why? Something psychologists call processing fluency. When information is easy for your brain to process, it doesn't just feel easier. It feels more *true*. In a 1999 study, Rolf Reber and Norbert Schwarz showed people statements printed in colors that were either easy or hard to read against the background. Same statements. People rated the easy-to-read ones as more likely to be true. Your brain mistakes "easy to process" for "probably correct."

3. REPEAT IT UNTIL IT'S TRUE

Add repetition. In 1977, researchers found that statements people heard more than once were rated as more believable, even when nobody checked whether they were true. It's called the illusory truth effect. Later studies found it works even on statements people *know* are false. That's why slogans get repeated a thousand times. "Yes we can." "Make America great again." "Lock her up." "Feel the Bern." Doesn't matter the side, the mechanism is the same.

4. RHYMES ARE MORE BELIEVABLE

And then there's rhyme. Researchers Matthew McGlone and Jessica Tofighbakhsh gave people

sayings in two versions. One rhymed, like "woes unite foes." The other meant exactly the same thing but didn't rhyme: "woes unite enemies." People rated the rhyming version as more accurate. It's called the rhyme-as-reason effect. "I like Ike" wasn't just catchy. It was persuasive by design.

5. SIMPLE ISN'T DUMB

To be fair: speaking simply is a skill, not a sign of low intelligence. Lincoln was simple *and* brilliant. Clear language includes more people. The problem isn't simplicity. It's that simple, repeated, rhyming phrases can make us feel certain about things we've never actually thought through.

OUTRO

So this week, try one thing. When a line hits you and you think "yeah, exactly," pause and ask: do I agree with this, or does it just sound good? That one question is the best defense your brain has against every campaign, from every side. Go vote, if you can. And tell me the most effective slogan you've ever heard. Not the best policy. The most effective *slogan*.

Visuals: text cards only. Show slogans in plain type, balanced between parties. Avoid politicians' photos and campaign footage (copyright, plus it reads as taking a side). Recheck the election date before posting (midterms: Tue Nov 3, 2026).

Sources:

- Everett spoke ~2 hours; Lincoln's Gettysburg Address ~272 words (Library of Congress).
- Schumacher, E., & Eskenazi, M. (2016). A readability analysis of campaign speeches from the 2016 US presidential campaign. Carnegie Mellon, Language Technologies Institute (arXiv). (Trump grammar ≈ grade 5.7; Lincoln ≈ 11th; not peer-reviewed.)
- Reber, R., & Schwarz, N. (1999). Effects of perceptual fluency on judgments of truth. *Consciousness and Cognition*, 8(3), 338–342.
- Hasher, L., Goldstein, D., & Toppino, T. (1977). Frequency and the conference of referential validity. *Journal of Verbal Learning and Verbal Behavior*, 16(1). Fazio, L. K., et al. (2015). Knowledge does not protect against illusory truth. *JEP: General*, 144(5).
- McGlone, M. S., & Tofighbakhsh, J. (2000). Birds of a feather flock conjointly (?): Rhyme as reason in aphorisms. *Psychological Science*, 11(5), 424–428.

P16: How politicians dodge questions without you noticing

- **Category:** Politics (**strictly nonpartisan**)
- **Concepts:** the "artful dodger" studies, equivocation research, attention and social evaluation, media-training "bridging"
- **Target length:** ~3:30 (~530 words) · regular video · timely around the midterms
- **Title:** The psychology of the political dodge (and how to catch it)
- **Thumbnail text:** "DID THEY ANSWER?"

COLD OPEN

Quick test. Think of the last political interview or debate clip you watched. Can you remember the exact question that was asked? Not the topic. The question. Most people can't. And politicians know that. Researchers have measured how often politicians actually answer the question they're asked, and how often you notice when they don't. Both numbers are worse than you'd hope.

1. HOW OFTEN THEY ANSWER

British psychologist Peter Bull has spent decades coding political interviews question by question. He's catalogued dozens of distinct ways politicians avoid answering. Across studies of televised interviews in the UK, politicians gave a clear, direct reply to fewer than four in ten questions. In one Japanese study, it was under one in ten. This isn't one party or one country. It's the job.

2. THE ARTFUL DODGER EXPERIMENT

In 2011, Harvard researchers Todd Rogers and Michael Norton ran an experiment. People watched a video of a speaker being asked a policy question in a mock debate. In one version, he answered it. In another, he smoothly answered a *different* question, on a related topic, as if it were the one he'd been asked. A lot of viewers didn't notice the dodge. And the ones who didn't notice didn't think any less of him. When the answer was about something totally unrelated, people caught it. But a dodge to a *similar* question slid right past.

3. WHY YOUR BRAIN MISSES IT

Rogers and Norton's explanation is my favorite part. When we watch someone talk, our brains aren't really asking, "Did he answer the question?" They're asking, "Do I like this person? Does he seem trustworthy?" We're judging the person, not checking the content. In their study, a speaker who answered the right question but stumbled over his words came off *worse* than a smooth speaker who dodged. Confidence beats correctness.

4. THE TECHNIQUE HAS A NAME
Media trainers teach this on purpose. It's often called "bridging": acknowledge the question, use a bridge phrase, then pivot to your talking point. "That's a great question, and what Americans really care about is..." Once you know the bridge phrases, you'll hear them everywhere: "Let me be clear," "The real issue here is," "What I'd say is."

5. THE FIX IS ALMOST TOO EASY
In the same research, one small change made viewers much better at spotting dodges: keeping the question written on screen while the person answered. That's it. When the question stays in front of you, your brain stops just judging the person and starts checking the answer. Some news networks have started doing exactly that.

OUTRO

So here's your homework for election week. Next time you watch an interview or debate, write the question down, or just say it out loud before the answer starts. Then ask: did they answer *that*? It works on every politician, from every side. Comment the most impressive dodge you've ever seen. Not the worst. The most *impressive*.

Visuals: recreate the experiment on camera. Show a question card, then "answer" a different question smoothly yourself, then reveal. No real politicians' footage needed, and that keeps it nonpartisan.

Sources:
- Bull, P., & Mayer, K. (1993). How not to answer questions in political interviews. *Political Psychology*, 14(4). Feldman, O., Kinoshita, K., & Bull, P. (2015). *Journal of Language and Social Psychology* (Japan: reply rate < 10%; UK and Taiwan interviews < 40%).
- Rogers, T., & Norton, M. I. (2011). The artful dodger: Answering the wrong question the right way. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Applied*, 17(2), 139–147.
- Bridging: standard media-training technique (e.g., the "acknowledge, bridge, communicate" model).

P17: Science says gamers peak at 24. Faker is 30 and going for a 4-peat.

- **Category:** Esports (League of Legends, Worlds 2026)
- **Concepts:** age-related decline in reaction speed (the StarCraft study), chunking and expertise, how much practice explains
- **Target length:** ~4:00 (~590 words) · regular video · **film before T1's next match, and update the bracket line**
- **Title:** Faker is breaking a rule of human performance
- **Thumbnail text:** "OVER THE HILL AT 24?"

COLD OPEN

Lee "Faker" Sang-hyeok won his first League of Legends World Championship in 2013. He was 17. He's now won six: 2013, 2015, 2016, 2023, 2024 and 2025. He's 30 years old, which in esports is basically ancient. And right now, at Worlds 2026 here in the United States, T1 is trying to win a fourth title in a row. There's a study that says this shouldn't be possible.

1. "OVER THE HILL AT 24"

In 2014, researchers at Simon Fraser University analyzed thousands of players in the strategy game StarCraft 2. They measured something specific: how fast a player reacts to new information on screen and acts on it. They found that speed starts declining around age 24. The paper's actual title is "Over the Hill at 24." In a game where milliseconds matter, that's a big deal. So by that math, Faker has been over the hill for six years.

2. SO HOW IS HE STILL WINNING?

The same study found something important: older players compensated. They used shortcuts and more efficient strategies to make up for the lost speed. And that connects to a classic chess study from 1973. Researchers William Chase and Herbert Simon showed chess masters and beginners a board for five seconds, then asked them to rebuild it. Masters crushed it, *if* the pieces came from a real game. When the pieces were placed randomly, masters were barely better than beginners. Experts don't have better memories. They see patterns, or "chunks," that beginners don't. Faker has seen more League of Legends situations than almost any human alive. When a fight starts, a younger player is reacting. Faker is *recognizing*.

3. IS IT JUST PRACTICE?

You've probably heard of the "10,000 hours" rule. The truth is messier. A big 2014 analysis by Brooke Macnamara and colleagues found that deliberate practice explains about a quarter of the differences in performance in games like chess. That's a lot, but it means three-quarters is something else: talent,

age, coaching, the team around you, and the mental side. And the mental side is where Faker stands out.

4. THE QUIET PART
Faker is famous for how calm he is. He's lost world finals, in 2017 and 2022, and come back. He went through long stretches where people said he was done. Sports psychologists call the ability to stay steady under pressure "emotional regulation," and in a best-of-five on the world stage, it might matter more than hand speed. Watch his face after a lost game. It barely changes. That's not a lack of emotion. That's control.

5. WHERE IT STANDS
[UPDATE BEFORE FILMING: T1 made the quarterfinals in Allen, Texas. Quarterfinals run around Nov 3–6, semifinals Nov 7–8, and the final is Nov 14 at the Barclays Center in Brooklyn. Say where T1 is right now.]

OUTRO

So the science isn't wrong. Raw speed really does fade. Faker is just proof that speed is only one part of being great. Experience turns into pattern recognition, and calm turns into wins. That's good news for anyone who thinks they're "too old" to get good at something. You might get slower. You also get wiser. Do you think T1 gets the four-peat? Put your prediction in the comments, and I'll pin the person who's right.

Visuals: Riot's fan-content policy ("Legal Jibber Jabber") allows game assets in videos with ad revenue, but says not to just rip esports broadcasts with light commentary. So: your face, plus 1–3 s of game visuals at most. Add the line "Not endorsed by Riot Games" to the description. Chess demo: set up a real board if you have one.

Sources:
- Faker: Worlds titles 2013, 2015, 2016, 2023, 2024, 2025; lost finals 2017, 2022 (Wikipedia; GosuGamers, "T1 claim sixth title," Nov 2025). Born May 1996.
- Worlds 2026: North America; Swiss stage and knockouts in Allen, TX; final Nov 14, Barclays Center (Wikipedia; Yahoo Sports). T1 reached the quarterfinals (RUR Esports, Oct 29, 2026).
- Thompson, J. J., Blair, M. R., & Henrey, A. J. (2014). Over the hill at 24: Persistent age-related cognitive-motor decline in reaction times in an ecologically valid video game task begins in early adulthood. *PLoS ONE*, 9(4), e94215.
- Chase, W. G., & Simon, H. A. (1973). Perception in chess. *Cognitive Psychology*, 4(1), 55–81.
- Macnamara, B. N., Hambrick, D. Z., & Oswald, F. L. (2014). Deliberate practice and performance in music, games, sports, education, and professions: A meta-analysis. *Psychological Science*, 25(8). (Games ≈ 26% of variance.)
- Riot Games, "Legal Jibber Jabber" fan content policy (riotgames.com/legal).

P18: The psychology of tilt (why you lose 5 games in a row)

- **Category:** Esports (with a nod to Worlds pressure)
- **Concepts:** tilt as emotional dysregulation, anger and risk-taking, emotion-regulation strategies, cyclic sighing
- **Target length:** ~3:45 (~560 words) · regular video
- **Title:** Why you tilt, and the 2-minute fix science actually supports
- **Thumbnail text:** "ONE MORE GAME"

COLD OPEN

You lose one game. Annoying, fine. You queue again, "to make up for it." Lose. Again. Lose. Now it's 2 AM, you've dropped a whole rank, and you're typing paragraphs at your jungler. Every gamer knows this feeling. It's called tilt, and it's one of the few gaming terms that psychologists now study for real. Even pros at Worlds deal with it, on a stage, in front of millions.

1. WHERE "TILT" COMES FROM

The word comes from pinball. Old pinball machines had a sensor: if you got frustrated and shook the machine too hard, it flashed TILT and your game ended. Poker players borrowed it for the moment a bad beat makes you play recklessly. Gamers took it from there. The meaning stayed the same: your emotions take over the controls.

2. WHAT TILT DOES TO YOUR BRAIN

Tilt is usually anger, and anger does something specific to decisions. Psychologists Jennifer Lerner and Dacher Keltner found that angry people see less risk than fearful people do. Anger makes you feel certain and in control, so you take bigger gambles. That's the overextended flash, the 1v3 dive, the "one more game" at 2 AM. Stress also eats up working memory, the part of your brain that tracks cooldowns, map timers and where the enemy jungler probably is. So you're making riskier calls with less information. That's the tilt spiral.

3. WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND

Tilt research is new, but it's growing. In 2024, researchers interviewed pro players and coaches and built one of the first questionnaires to actually measure tilt in esports. A large survey of over a thousand gamers, also from 2024, found two things that protected people from tilting: more years of experience, and using healthy emotion-regulation strategies, like reframing a loss, instead of stewing on it or bottling it up. Other work suggests toxic chat makes tilt worse, beyond anything about your own emotional control. So muting all chat isn't weak. It's evidence-based.

4. THE 2-MINUTE FIX

Here's the most practical part. In a 2023 Stanford study, people did just five minutes a day of different breathing exercises or mindfulness meditation. The one that improved mood the most was "cyclic sighing": two inhales through the nose, the second one topping off the first, then one long, slow exhale through the mouth. Long exhales activate the part of your nervous system that calms you down. So between games: stand up, do a few rounds of that, and only queue again if you'd be happy to play even if you lose.

5. THE PRO VERSION

At Worlds, teams use the same basic tools: short resets between games, coaches reframing mistakes, routines that bring players back to the present. The difference between a pro and a tilted solo-queue player usually isn't that the pro doesn't *feel* it. It's that they have a system for what happens next.

OUTRO

So the rule is simple: after two losses in a row, take five minutes and breathe before you queue. Your rank will thank you. Comment your worst tilt story. I need to know I'm not alone.

Visuals: demo the breathing on camera, slowly. Optional 1–3 s League gameplay from your own account (Riot's fan-content policy allows it with original commentary). Not endorsed by Riot Games.

Sources:

- Lerner, J. S., & Keltner, D. (2001). Fear, anger, and risk. *JPSP*, 81(1), 146–159.
- Tilt scale development and the survey of 1,007 gamers: *Frontiers in Psychology* (2024), e.g., doi 10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1409368; University of Limerick, "The psychology of tilt."
- Toxicity predicts tilt beyond emotion regulation: APS convention posters (2024, 2026).
- Balban, M. Y., Neri, E., et al. (2023). Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal. *Cell Reports Medicine*, 4(1), 100895.
- Ties to Lecture 8 (coping, relaxation training).

H01: The Great Emu War

- **Story:** Western Australia, Nov–Dec 1932
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** Australia went to war with birds and lost
- **Hook text on screen:** "Australia vs. emus (1932)"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1932, Australia went to war with birds. And lost.

BEAT 1: the problem

After World War One, Australia gave veterans farmland in Western Australia. Then around 20,000 emus showed up and started eating the wheat.

BEAT 2: the army

So the government sent the army: Major Meredith, two machine guns, and ten thousand rounds of ammo. Turns out emus run about 30 miles an hour, scatter the second you shoot, and can take a hit and keep running. One gun jammed. They tried mounting a gun on a truck. The truck couldn't keep up.

BEAT 3: the score

After about a month, Meredith claimed 986 kills using almost 10,000 bullets. That's ten bullets per bird. He reportedly said that if he had a military division with the bullet-carrying capacity of these birds, it would face any army in the world.

ENDING

The army pulled out. The emus stayed. Farmers went back to paying bounties on emus, which worked way better. Final score: Australia zero, emus one.

Filming notes: this works deadpan. Hold up fingers for the "zero / one" score. Text overlays: "20,000 emus", "986 kills / 9,860 bullets".

Sources: Murray Johnson (2006), "'Feathered foes': soldier settlers and Western Australia's 'Emu War' of 1932," *Journal of Australian Studies*; the kill count is Meredith's own report (numbers vary by source, so say "claimed"). The quote's wording comes from later retellings with no 1932 original found, so keep "reportedly". Web-checked 2026-10-23: Wikipedia: Emu War (bounty scheme from 1923 continued; 57,034 bounties claimed in 6 months of 1934); emu top speed ~50 km/h ≈ 31 mph.

H02: Napoleon wasn't short

- **Story:** Napoleon's height myth and British propaganda
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** Napoleon wasn't short. He lost a meme war.
- **Hook text on screen:** "Napoleon was average height"

HOOK (0–3 s)

Napoleon wasn't short. He got roasted by British cartoonists.

BEAT 1: the units

When he died, his height was written down as five foot two. But that was in *French* units, and the French inch was longer than the English one. In modern terms he was about five-six, five-seven. Pretty average for a Frenchman back then.

BEAT 2: the cartoons

Then there's James Gillray, a British cartoonist who drew him as a tiny, tantrum-throwing "Little Boney." Britain was at war with him, so the joke spread everywhere.

BEAT 3: bad luck

It didn't help that his soldiers' nickname for him was "the little corporal," which was actually affectionate. Or that he was usually surrounded by his Imperial Guard, who had to be tall to get in.

ENDING

So the guy who ran most of Europe lost one war: the meme war. Two hundred years later, we still say "Napoleon complex."

Filming notes: the history avatar is a bicorne hat, so a paper bicorne (folded newspaper) on the hook would tie the channel together. Free prop.

Sources: autopsy measurement of 5 pieds 2 pouces (≈ 1.68–1.69 m); Gillray's "Little Boney" caricatures (British Museum collection); Andrew Roberts, *Napoleon: A Life* (2014).

H03: The Dancing Plague of 1518

- **Story:** Strasbourg, July 1518 (history × psychology crossover)
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** In 1518, a whole town couldn't stop dancing
- **Hook text on screen:** "They danced for weeks"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1518, a woman started dancing in the street. And she couldn't stop.

BEAT 1: it spreads

Strasbourg, July 1518. A woman known as Frau Troffea starts dancing and keeps going for days. Within weeks, dozens of people have joined her. Some accounts say hundreds.

BEAT 2: the "cure"

The city's solution? More dancing. Officials figured people had to dance it out of their system, so they opened up halls, built a stage, and hired musicians. It made it worse.

BEAT 3: the end

Some dancers collapsed from exhaustion. Finally the city banned public dancing and sent the dancers to a shrine of Saint Vitus to pray, and it slowly died out.

ENDING

So what was it? The leading theory is mass psychogenic illness. Famine, disease, extreme stress, and a local belief that a saint could curse you to dance. Fear spread through a crowd until their bodies acted it out. Follow for more history where the real cause was the human brain.

Filming notes: start the hook mid-sway, then stop and talk. The ending ties into the psych channel, so it's a good cross-promo later.

Sources: John Waller, *A Time to Dance, a Time to Die: The Extraordinary Story of the Dancing Plague of 1518* (2008). Death counts are disputed, so the script doesn't give one.

H04: The Boston Molasses Flood

- **Story:** North End, Boston, January 15, 1919
- **Target length:** ~50 s (~150 words)
- **Title:** A 25-foot wave of molasses hit Boston
- **Hook text on screen:** "Boston, 1919: death by molasses"

HOOK (0–3 s)

In 1919, a wave of molasses tore through Boston at 35 miles an hour.

BEAT 1: the tank

January 15th, 1919. In Boston's North End, a giant tank holding over two million gallons of molasses, used to make industrial alcohol, suddenly bursts.

BEAT 2: the wave

A wave up to 25 feet tall rolls through the streets. It knocks buildings off their foundations and bends the elevated train tracks. And in the January cold, the molasses got thicker as it cooled, so people caught in it couldn't get out. 21 people died, and about 150 were hurt.

BEAT 3: the cover-up

The company blamed anarchists. The court didn't buy it. The tank had never been properly tested, and it leaked so badly that the company painted it brown so the leaks wouldn't show.

ENDING

The disaster pushed Boston, and later other states, to require engineers to sign off on plans like this. And locals said that on hot days, the North End smelled like molasses for decades.

Filming notes: keep the tone respectful in beat 2 (21 deaths). A jar of syrup or molasses as a prop works for the hook.

Sources: Stephen Puleo, *Dark Tide: The Great Boston Molasses Flood of 1919* (2003); Massachusetts Historical Society; the 2016 Harvard fluid-dynamics analysis (Nicole Sharp & Jordan Kennedy) on why the cold made it deadlier. Web-checked 2026-10-23: Wikipedia, Mass Moments

(brown paint, anarchist claim, auditor Hugh Ogden ruled against the company in 1925), Boston.gov (engineer sign-off rules). Wave height (8–25 ft) and speed (30–35 mph) vary by source; 25 ft / 35 mph are Puleo's figures.

H05: Cleopatra lived closer to the Moon landing than to the pyramids

- **Story:** time-scale fact + who Cleopatra actually was
- **Target length:** ~45 s (~140 words)
- **Title:** Cleopatra is closer to us than to the pyramids
- **Hook text on screen:** "Pyramids → Cleopatra: 2,500 yrs. Cleopatra → Moon: 2,000 yrs."

HOOK (0–3 s)

Cleopatra lived closer in time to the Moon landing than to the building of the Great Pyramid.

BEAT 1: the math

The Great Pyramid was finished around 2560 BC. Cleopatra died in 30 BC. That's about 2,500 years. From Cleopatra to Neil Armstrong? About 2,000.

BEAT 2: what that means

To Cleopatra, the pyramids were already ancient. They were as old to her as Confucius is to us.

BEAT 3: who she was

And she wasn't ethnically Egyptian. Her family, the Ptolemies, were Greek-Macedonian, descended from one of Alexander the Great's generals. They ruled Egypt for almost 300 years, and Cleopatra was reportedly the first one in the family to actually learn Egyptian.

ENDING

Ancient history isn't one big blob. Some of it was ancient even to the ancients. Follow for more history that breaks your sense of time.

Filming notes: draw a simple timeline on paper (pyramid → Cleopatra → rocket) and point along it, or put the timeline in as a text overlay in CapCut.

Sources: Great Pyramid ≈ 2560 BC (Encyclopaedia Britannica); Cleopatra VII, 69–30 BC; Ptolemaic dynasty 305–30 BC; Plutarch, *Life of Antony* 27, on her being the first of her line to learn Egyptian. Confucius 551–479 BC.